

>>> E-mail

Electronic communication (e-mail) has become the preferred means of communication in most organizations. Some of us receive 100 or more messages a day. Because e-mail can be sent internally, within an organization, or externally, from one organization to another, specific e-mail guidelines are added to the general guidelines for correspondence earlier in the chapter.

Guidelines for E-mail

When writing e-mail, you should try to strike a balance between speed of delivery on one hand and quality of the communication to your reader on the other. In fact, the overriding rule for e-mail is as follows:

Don't send it too quickly!



Ryan McVay/Thinkstock

By taking an extra minute to check the style and tone of your message, you have the best chance of sending an e-mail that will be well received.

>> E-mail Guideline 1: Use Style Appropriate to the Reader and Subject

E-mail sent early in a relationship with a client or other professional contact should be somewhat formal. It should be written more like a letter, with a salutation, closing, and complete sentences. E-mail written once a professional relationship has been established can use a more casual style. It can resemble conversation with the recipient on the phone. Sentence fragments and slang are acceptable, as long as they contribute to your objectives and are in good taste. Most important, avoid displaying a negative or angry tone. Don't push the Send button unless an e-mail will produce a constructive exchange.

>> E-mail Guideline 2: Be Sure Your Message Indicates the Context to Which It Applies

Tell your readers what the subject is and what prompted you to write your message. If you are replying to a message, be sure to include the previous message or summarize the message to which you are replying. Most e-mail software packages include a copy of the message to which you are replying, as in Model 6-3. However, you should make sure that you include only the messages that provide the context for your reader. Long strings of forwarded e-mail make it difficult to find the necessary information.

>> E-mail Guideline 3: Choose the Most Appropriate Method for Replying to a Message

Short e-mail messages may require that you write only a brief response at the beginning or end of the e-mail to which you are responding. For complex, multitopic messages, however, you may wish to split your reply by commenting on each point individually (Figure 6-5).

>> E-mail Guideline 4: Format Your Message Carefully

Because e-mail messages frequently replace more formal print-based documents, they should be organized and formatted so that the readers can easily locate the information you want to communicate.

- Use headings to identify important chunks of information.
- Use lists to display a series of information.
- Use sufficient white space to separate important chunks of information.
- Use separators to divide one piece of information from another.

Figure 6-6 illustrates an e-mail message with headings, separators, and white space.

>> E-mail Guideline 5: Chunk Information for Easy Scanning

Break the information into coherent chunks dealing with one specific topic, including all the details that a reader needs to get all of the essential information. Depending on

■ **Model 6-6** ■
E-mail message
with use of
appropriate
headings,
separators, and
white space

Date: Tue, 7 Oct. 2012 09:25:30 -0800
To: Branch employees
From: Paul Carmichael <pcarmich@advantage.com>
Subject: October update
Mime-Version: 1.0

This is the October Electronic Update for Advantage, Inc. If you do not wish to
receive this electronic update, send a message to

pcarmich@advantage.com

With the message in the subject line: Unsubscribe.

UPCOMING EVENTS

Project managers' meeting

October 21 — project managers meeting (notice the change of location):
Hereford building, room 209.

November department meetings
All departments will have their planning and reporting meetings on November
18 at noon, with a joint lunch in the main dining room and breakout sessions at
12:30. Meetings should conclude at 2 p.m.

December department meetings

NOTE CHANGE OF DATE: The December department meetings will be held on
December 10 (second Wednesday), NOT December 17 (third Wednesday).

the nature of the information, include specific topic, time, date, location, and necessary prerequisites and details.

>> E-mail Guideline 6: Use Copy Options Carefully

E-mail makes it easy to send copies of the same message to a large number of people at once. Using this technique can be helpful, but it can also clog readers' inboxes with unwanted mail. Before you copy someone, make sure that person really needs to see

the message that you are sending. Also think carefully about how you list the recipients. The “To:” line indicates a primary audience of decision makers, participants, or operators. (See Chapter 2 for more on types of readers.) The “Cc:” line indicates a secondary audience that needs to be informed about the subject but is not expected to act. Finally, use the “Bc:” line very carefully. Copying someone without informing the person to whom the e-mail is addressed can be considered unethical. One good use of the “Bc:” line is to send a copy of your e-mail message to yourself, for your own records.

>> E-mail Guideline 7: When Writing to Groups, Give Readers a Method to Abstain from Receiving Future Notices

E-mail can easily become invasive and troublesome for recipients. You will gain favor—or at least not lose favor—if you are considerate and allow recipients to decide what e-mail they wish to receive. Figure 6–6 includes information about how to unsubscribe from the branch’s employee e-mail list.

>> E-mail Guideline 8: When Writing to Groups, Suppress the E-mail Addresses of Recipients—Unless the Group Has Agreed to Let Addresses Be Known

It is inappropriate to reveal the e-mail addresses of group members to other group members. Use the “Bc:” line to suppress group members’ addresses.

>> E-mail Guideline 9: When Composing an Important Message, Consider Composing It With Your Word Processor

Important e-mail messages should be not only clear in format but also correct in mechanics. Because e-mail software may not have a spelling checker, compose important messages with your word processor and use your spelling checker to check accuracy. Then either cut and paste it into an e-mail message or attach it as a file.

ABC Format for E-mail

Simply understanding that e-mail *should* have a format puts you ahead of many writers, who consider e-mail a license to ramble on without structure. Yes, e-mail is casual and quick, but that does not make it formless. The three-part ABC format resembles that used for letters.

Remember—your reader is confronted with many e-mails during the day. Furthermore, the configurations of some computers make reading a screen harder on the eyes than reading

E-mail Guidelines

- Use style appropriate to the reader and subject
- Be sure your message indicates the context to which it applies
- Choose the most appropriate method for replying to a message
- Format your message carefully
- Chunk information for easy scanning
- Use Copy options carefully
- When writing to groups, give readers a method to abstain from receiving future notices
- When writing to groups, suppress the e-mail addresses of recipients
- When composing an important message, consider composing it with your word processor

ABC Format: E-mail

- **ABSTRACT:** Casual, friendly greeting if justified by relationship
 - Short, clear statement of purpose for writing
 - List of main topics to be covered
- **BODY:** Supporting information for points mentioned in abstract
 - Use of short paragraphs that start with main ideas
 - Use of headings and lists
 - Use of abbreviations and jargon only when understood by all readers
- **CONCLUSION:** Summary of main point
 - Clarity about action that comes next

print memos. So give each e-mail a structure that makes it simple for your reader to find important information.

Appropriate Use and Style for E-mail

E-mail is an appropriate reflection of the speed at which we conduct business today. Indeed, it mirrors the pace of popular culture as well. Following are some of the obvious advantages that using e-mail provides:

- It gets to the intended receiver quickly.
- Its arrival can be confirmed easily.
- Your reader can reply to your message quickly.
- It's cheap to use—once you have invested in the hardware and software.
- It permits cheap transmission of multiple copies and attachments.

Adding to the ease of transmission is the fact that e-mail allows you to create mailing lists. One address label can be an umbrella for multiple recipients, saving you much time.

Of course, remember the flip side of this ease of use: E-mail is *not* private. Every time you send an e-mail, remember that it may be archived or forwarded, and may end up being read by “the world.” Either by mistake or design, many supposedly private e-mails are received by unintended readers.

E-mail communication is often considered less formal and therefore less demanding in its format and structure than print-based messages such as memos and letters. However, because e-mail messages have become so pervasive a means of communication, you should consider constructing them as carefully as you would other correspondence. Another reason to exercise great care is that e-mail, like conventional documents, can be used in legal proceedings and other formal contexts.

Chapter 3, which mentions e-mail in the context of team writing, shows how electronic mail helps you collaborate with others during the writing process—especially the planning stage. Interestingly, the e-mail medium has produced a casual writing style similar to that of handwritten notes. It even has its own set of abbreviations and shortcut languages, which ranges so widely and changes so often that no list of abbreviations is included here. Following is an e-mail message from one M-Global employee to another. Josh Bergen and Natalie Long are working together on a report in which they must offer suggestions for designing an operator’s control panel at a large dam. Josh has just learned about another control panel that M-Global designed and installed for a Russian nuclear power plant (see Model 12–6 on pages 472–478). Josh wrote this e-mail message to draw Natalie’s attention to the related M-Global project: